

DOC 2 — VOCABULARY IN CONTEXT: 80 SOLUTIONS

Digital SAT Reading & Writing — Answer Key & Explanations

Q1. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The passage says researchers found venom glands, providing "an alternative explanation" for prey death. This challenges the old bacterial-infection idea.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "validated" means confirmed — opposite of what happens when an alternative explanation emerges.

C) "replicated" means reproduced — the study didn't repeat the hypothesis; it challenged it.

B) "publicized" means made widely known — the passage is about disproving, not promoting.

D) ■ CORRECT — "undermined" means weakened the foundation of the old hypothesis.

TRAP ALERT ■ "validated" is the classic reversal trap.

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Alternative explanation" = old one weakened.

FAST METHOD ■ "Validated the hypothesis by providing an alternative" is contradictory. Only "undermined" fits.

Q2. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The behavior is "not merely decorative" but has "a clear purpose." The blank needs a word meaning "fulfills."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "obscures" means hides — opposite of having a clear purpose.

B) ■ CORRECT — "serves a clear purpose" is a natural collocation.

C) "disputes" means argues against — a behavior cannot argue against a purpose.

D) "abandons" means gives up — incoherent with "a clear purpose."

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Not merely X but [blank] Y" signals a contrast — the second part must be positive.

FAST METHOD ■ "Serves a purpose" is idiomatic.

Q3. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Warming → ice retreats → bears travel farther. The blank describes a cause-and-effect consequence.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "relief" means easing — the passage describes a negative effect.

B) "luxury" means indulgence — nonsensical.

C) "approval" means endorsement — warming doesn't endorse hunting ranges.

D) ■ CORRECT — "impact" means an effect or influence, fitting the cause-and-effect.

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Measurable [blank] on" → "measurable impact on" is standard academic phrasing.

Q4. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Predicted "steady growth" vs. actual "erratic fluctuations." Results go against expectations.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) ■ CORRECT — "defy" means go against or resist expectations.

- B) "confirm" means verify — opposite; results don't match predictions.
- C) "echo" means repeat — synonym of "confirm," not a contrast word.
- D) "celebrate" means honor — results don't celebrate expectations.

TRAP ALERT ■ "confirm" is the reversal trap.

KEY INSIGHT ■ "While" sets up a contrast: "steady" vs. "erratic" → contradiction.

Q5. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Subways = lower congestion. This aligns with the "widely held view." Findings are consistent.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "reject" means dismiss — findings align, not oppose.
- B) "confuse" means muddle — findings don't make a view unclear.
- C) "exaggerate" means overstate — findings don't overstate a view.

D) ■ CORRECT — "support" means provide evidence for the view.

FAST METHOD ■ Lower congestion + subway = supports the idea that subways reduce congestion.

Q6. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Grandmother oversees her garden with "careful precision" and "iron will." "Ran" = operated/managed.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "Sprinted through" is the literal meaning — context is about oversight.
- B) ■ CORRECT — "Managed" fits overseeing the garden.**
- C) "Dissolved" — no connection to context.
- D) "Advertised" — irrelevant.

TRAP ALERT ■ Literal meaning of "ran" (physical movement) is the trap.

Q7. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: "Air was thick with the scent" = air was heavily filled with smells.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) ■ CORRECT — "Dense" fits: air heavily saturated with smells.**
- B) "Wide" refers to breadth — not how air works.
- C) "Stupid" is informal slang — irrelevant.
- D) "Solid" implies rigid physical state — air isn't solid.

FAST METHOD ■ "The air was dense with the scent" works perfectly.

Q8. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Journey went from months to less than a week. Times decreased.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "extended" means lengthened — opposite.
- B) "invented" — travel times aren't invented.
- C) "ignored" — times weren't ignored; they changed.
- D) ■ CORRECT — "reduced" means decreased.**

FAST METHOD ■ Months → less than a week = reduced.

Q9. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Families commissioned artworks and provided "financial resources" = supported/sponsored.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) ■ CORRECT — "patronized" means financially supported (as patrons of the arts).

B) "penalized" means punished — opposite.

C) "abandoned" means deserted — contradicts "commissioning."

D) "imitated" means copied — they funded artists, not copied them.

TRAP ALERT ■ Some know "patronized" as "talked down to." In academic contexts, it means "acted as a patron."

Q10. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Baobab fruit could help with vitamin deficiencies. Blank = "deal with" or "remedy."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) ■ CORRECT — "address" means deal with or tackle a problem.

B) "intensify" means make worse — opposite.

C) "overlook" means ignore — opposite of solving.

D) "mimic" means imitate — you don't imitate a deficiency.

FAST METHOD ■ "Address a deficiency" is standard academic phrasing.

Q11. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Short intervals beat long sessions. The "common belief" is longer = better. Findings oppose this.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "illustrate" means demonstrate — would mean confirming the belief, but findings oppose it.

B) "restore" means bring back — the belief hasn't been lost.

C) "adopt" means embrace — results don't adopt beliefs.

D) ■ CORRECT — "contradict" means go against.

TRAP ALERT ■ "illustrate" is tempting because results "show" something — but they show the opposite of the belief.

Q12. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Voice "carried no weight of sadness" = didn't convey the emotional burden/load of sadness.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "Heaviness" — too physical; "burden" better captures the emotional sense.

B) ■ CORRECT — "Burden" captures the emotional load.

C) "Measurement" — irrelevant to sadness.

D) "Importance" — sentence is about emotional tone, not significance.

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Weight of sadness" is metaphorical — about emotional load, not physical mass.

Q13. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: "Even minor disturbances" cause "widespread" damage. Small changes → big problems = delicate.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) ■ CORRECT — "fragile" means easily damaged.

B) "resilient" means tough — opposite.

C) "artificial" means human-made — reefs are natural.

D) "permanent" means lasting forever — contradicted by bleaching.

TRAP ALERT ■ "resilient" is the reversal — students focusing on 25% of species may think reefs are strong.

KEY INSIGHT ■ Small cause → big effect = fragile.

Q14. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Printing reduced costs, but books "remained expensive." Books NOT made cheaply available right away.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "invisible" — passage is about cost, not visibility.

B) "identical" — irrelevant to affordability.

C) "controversial" — not related to cost.

D) ■ CORRECT — "affordable" means inexpensive enough to buy, which didn't immediately happen.

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Did not immediately make books [blank]" + "remained expensive" → blank = affordable.

Q15. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Knowledge was "surprisingly" advanced, including blood circulation = detailed/advanced.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "superficial" means shallow — contradicts "surprisingly" and specific knowledge.

B) "reluctant" means unwilling — describes attitude, not understanding quality.

C) ■ CORRECT — "sophisticated" means complex and advanced.

D) "fictional" means imaginary — knowledge is presented as real.

Q16. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: "Hold court" = preside over an audience. She speaks with authority while others listen.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) A legal tribunal — no legal setting.

B) A royal assembly — figurative use means audience, not literal royalty.

C) ■ CORRECT — "An audience" fits: she presides while others listen.

D) A sports arena — no athletic context.

Q17. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Early start times don't match teens' shift toward later sleep. Mismatch → fatigue.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "align with" means match — opposite of mismatch.

B) "contribute to" — doesn't capture the adversarial relationship.

C) "originate from" — start times don't come from rhythms.

D) ■ CORRECT — "conflict with" means clash.

FAST METHOD ■ Early ≠ late → conflict.

Q18. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: "The work demanded patience" = the work required patience.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "Ordered aggressively" — work doesn't aggressively order patience.

B) "Requested formally" — work doesn't make polite requests.

C) ■ CORRECT — "Required" fits perfectly.

D) "Questioned" — irrelevant.

Q19. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Tokens were "an early form of bookkeeping." Blank = "constituted" or "served as."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) ■ CORRECT — "represented" means constituted or served as.

B) "destroyed" — contradicts the idea of a precursor.

C) "concealed" means hid — tokens were a known development.

D) "delayed" — tokens didn't postpone bookkeeping; they were bookkeeping.

Q20. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Monarch decline linked to herbicide use, which removes milkweed. Blank = "removal."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "discovery" — milkweed wasn't found; it was lost.

B) "decoration" — irrelevant to ecology.

C) "cultivation" means growing — opposite of removal by herbicides.

D) ■ CORRECT — "disappearance" means vanishing, caused by herbicides.

Q21. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Toddlers switch between languages = "code-switching." Blank = "switch back and forth."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) ■ CORRECT — "alternate" means switch back and forth.

B) "struggle" implies difficulty — passage says this is sophisticated.

C) "hesitate" means pause uncertainly — contradicts positive framing.

D) "compete" — languages don't compete within a sentence here.

TRAP ALERT ■ "struggle" and "hesitate" imply the negative interpretation the passage rejects.

Q22. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: "Could draw a sharp look" = "could cause/provoke" a sharp look.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "Sketch" — a pencil doesn't sketch a look.
- B) "Pull" — doesn't fit "a sharp look."
- C) ■ CORRECT — "Provoke" means cause or elicit.**
- D) "Illustrate" — doesn't fit.

TRAP ALERT ■ Mention of a pencil makes "sketch" tempting, but the object is "a sharp look."

Q23. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Roads enabled movement, trade, and exchange. Blank = "made easier."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "prohibited" means forbade — opposite.
 - B) ■ CORRECT — "facilitated" means made easier or enabled.**
 - C) "criticized" — infrastructure doesn't criticize.
 - D) "memorized" — nonsensical.
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Q24. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Extreme heat by day vs. freezing at night = "dramatic" change. Blank = "shift."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "similarity" — temperatures are opposites.
 - B) "average" — passage is about extremes, not averages.
 - C) ■ CORRECT — "swing" means a wide shift between extremes.**
 - D) "ceiling" — doesn't describe range between high and low.
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Q25. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Adding satellite data would improve accuracy. Blank = "strengthen."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) ■ CORRECT — "bolster" means strengthen or reinforce.**
 - B) "replicate" means copy — not improving.
 - C) "diminish" means reduce — opposite.
 - D) "postpone" means delay — accuracy isn't delayed.
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Q26. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Sitar has changed: steel strings, moveable frets, different chambers. Blank = "change."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "neglect" — it's being changed, not ignored.
- B) "preservation" means keeping same — contradicts changes.
- C) ■ CORRECT — "modification" means alteration.**
- D) "censorship" — irrelevant.

TRAP ALERT ■ "preservation" is the reversal — "traditional instrument" might trigger the word about keeping traditions.

Q27. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Municipal turnout is lower than national. Blank describes this gap.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) ■ CORRECT — "disparity" means a gap or inequality.**
 - B) "surplus" means excess — there isn't excess turnout.
 - C) "uniformity" means sameness — opposite of a gap.
 - D) "incentive" — describes motivation, not the gap itself.
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Q28. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Children "usually restless" were stopped by "the gravity of the moment."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "Detained by police" — no law enforcement present.
- B) ■ CORRECT — "Halted" means stopped.**
- C) "Accused" — children aren't being accused.
- D) "Frightened" — passage describes solemnity, not fear.

TRAP ALERT ■ Legal meaning of "arrested" is the primary trap.

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Arrested by the gravity" = stopped/held in place by seriousness.

Q29. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: "Although" contrasts "endangered in the wild" with lab success. Despite bad news in nature, it does well in labs.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "deteriorates" means declines — continues bad news, no contrast.
- B) "competes" — competes with what? Nothing mentioned.
- C) "hides" — doesn't address doing well.
- D) ■ CORRECT — "thrives" means flourishes, providing the required contrast.**

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Although" = contrast. Endangered (negative) → blank must be positive → thrives.

Q30. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Tone-language speakers have "heightened ability" to perceive pitch differences. Blank = "detect."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) ■ CORRECT — "discern" means detect subtle differences.**
 - B) "generate" means create — they perceive, not create.
 - C) "disregard" means ignore — opposite.
 - D) "broadcast" means transmit — they aren't sending out differences.
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Q31. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: "Rigid economy in all things, including affection" = sparing and restrained.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "Financial system" — affection isn't financial.
- B) "Bargain" — doesn't fit "rigid bargain in affection."

C) ■ CORRECT — "Restraint" means careful limitation.

D) "Wealth" means abundance — opposite.

TRAP ALERT ■ Financial meaning is the primary trap. "Economy" can mean frugality/restraint.

Q32. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Glass buildings in hot climates increase energy costs → opposes sustainability goals.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "advancing" means promoting — higher costs don't promote sustainability.

B) "illustrating" — buildings don't demonstrate goals; they work against them.

C) ■ CORRECT — "undermining" means weakening from within.

D) "measuring" — buildings don't measure goals.

Q33. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: "Despite...solitary predators" + sharing kills + tolerating others = communal behaviors.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "aggressive" would align with "solitary predators," not contrast.

B) "territorial" also aligns — not a surprise.

C) ■ CORRECT — "social" contrasts with "solitary."

D) "predatory" would be expected — not "unexpected."

Q34. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Higher-density zoning and transit = tools to limit outward expansion.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) ■ CORRECT — "curtail" means reduce or limit.

B) "promote" means encourage — policies fight sprawl, not encourage it.

C) "define" — you don't define sprawl with zoning.

D) "disguise" means conceal — policies don't hide sprawl.

Q35. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Krupov's gesture was "a feint, designed to rattle his opponent" — done on purpose.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "Slow" — "deliberate" can mean slow, but context emphasizes purposefulness ("designed to rattle").

B) "Accidental" — opposite of intentional.

C) "Obvious" — passage doesn't focus on visibility.

D) ■ CORRECT — "Intentional" means done on purpose.

TRAP ALERT ■ "Slow" is the trap — but "designed to rattle" confirms purpose, not pace.

Q36. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: "Sudden eruption" oversimplifies. Reality: "years" of factors "gradually eroded" confidence.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "instantaneous" — the oversimplification the passage rejects.

B) "secretive" — the process wasn't secret; it was slow.

C) "entertaining" — irrelevant.

D) ■ CORRECT — "gradual" matches "years" and "gradually."

FAST METHOD ■ "Sudden" = oversimplification; reality = "gradual."

Q37. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Not just fatigue but also memory impairment = worse/broader than thought.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) ■ CORRECT — "more extensive than" means broader than previously understood.

B) "less significant than" — reversal.

C) "identical to what was" — passage reveals new, additional effects.

D) "unrelated to what was" — effects are related but broader.

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Not merely...but also" = more than previously thought.

Q38. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Trees lower temperatures. Heat island raises them. Trees counteract heat.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) ■ CORRECT — "mitigate" means reduce severity.

B) "intensify" — opposite.

C) "replicate" means copy — trees don't copy heat.

D) "inaugurate" means begin — the effect already exists.

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Mitigate" is the standard word for reducing a negative effect.

Q39. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Uncle waits for seller to "soften," then pushes harder. "Press advantage" = capitalize.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "Iron" (pressing clothes) — irrelevant.

B) "Publish" (press release) — irrelevant.

C) ■ CORRECT — "Push" means advance forcefully.

D) "Squeeze" — doesn't fit "his advantage."

Q40. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Devices go unused, people lack training. Shortage in digital literacy.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "surplus" means excess — opposite.

B) "trend" — doesn't describe a shortage.

C) "innovation" — not about novelty.

D) ■ CORRECT — "dearth" means scarcity or lack.

TRAP ALERT ■ "surplus" is the reversal.

Q41. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Telemann "overshadowed" by Bach. Kowalski says "unwarranted." Blank = being overlooked.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "collaboration" — not related to being overshadowed.
- B) "celebrity" means fame — opposite.
- C) ■ CORRECT — "neglect" means being overlooked.**
- D) "imitation" — he isn't being copied; he's being ignored.

Q42. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Turtles attracted to artificial light, drawn toward danger.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) ■ CORRECT — "lures" means attracts, often toward something harmful.**
- B) "shields" means protects — light doesn't protect.
- C) "releases" — doesn't capture attraction.
- D) "distinguishes" — doesn't fit.

Q43. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: "Composure he wore like armor" = displayed composure as protective covering.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "Eroded" — "like armor" confirms the clothing/display meaning, not wear-and-tear.
- B) ■ CORRECT — "Displayed" means showed outwardly.**
- C) "Purchased" — you don't purchase composure.
- D) "Damaged" — doesn't fit "like armor."

Q44. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: T. rex supplemented diet by scavenging = taking advantage of available food.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "herbivorous" — passage describes scavenging carcasses, not eating plants.
- B) "aquatic" — no water connection.
- C) "nocturnal" — about diet, not timing.
- D) ■ CORRECT — "opportunistic" means taking advantage of available opportunities.**

TRAP ALERT ■ "herbivorous" might attract students who think "not exclusively predatory" = plant-eating. The alternative is scavenging.

Q45. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Multitasking (divided attention) → worse critical thinking. Requires the opposite: focused attention.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) ■ CORRECT — "sustained" means continuous and focused.**
- B) "divided" — this is what fails, not what's needed.
- C) "fleeting" means brief — wouldn't support critical thinking.

D) "peripheral" means marginal — opposite of focused.

KEY INSIGHT ■ Distraction → failure. Therefore success requires sustained attention.

Q46. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Most scholars: quipus = numbers. Fuentes: "far more [blank]," including narratives = broader.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "limited" — opposite of broader.

B) "conventional" — Fuentes argues against the conventional view.

C) "obsolete" — irrelevant to scope.

D) ■ CORRECT — "expansive" means broad or wide-ranging.

FAST METHOD ■ Numbers only → numbers + narratives = more expansive.

Q47. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Aunt Viviana "harbored a single, surprising concession" = kept one exception.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "Sheltered ships" — no maritime context.

B) ■ CORRECT — "Maintained" means kept or held.

C) "Suspected" — different collocation; object here is "a concession," not suspicion.

D) "Envied" — she didn't envy the concession.

Q48. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Assumption: all food chains need photosynthesis. Chemosynthesis challenges this.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) ■ CORRECT — "depend on" means rely on.

B) "interfere with" — food chains don't disrupt photosynthesis.

C) "originate before" — not about temporal order.

D) "compete against" — food chains don't rival photosynthesis.

Q49. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Past: criticism. Present: "record prices at auction." Blank = current high status.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "obscure" means unknown — contradicts "record prices."

B) "austere" means severe/plain — describes style, not status.

C) "controversial" — was true in the past, not the present.

D) ■ CORRECT — "revered" means deeply respected and admired.

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Initially...criticism" → "Today, however" = past negative → present positive.

Q50. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Failed approach: one factor. Recommended: multiple factors = more careful/systematic.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "perfunctory" — describes the failing approach, not the recommended one.
B) "impulsive" — also opposite.
C) ■ CORRECT — "methodical" means systematic and thorough.
D) "decorative" — irrelevant.
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Q51. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Writers used fiction for "social commentary" and "pointed critiques." Blank = "reveal."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "conceal" — opposite.
B) ■ CORRECT — "expose" means reveal or bring to attention.
C) "endorse" — they critiqued inequities, not supported them.
D) "replicate" — they weren't copying inequities.
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Q52. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Advantage is "modest" — comparing bilingual vs. monolingual performance.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) ■ CORRECT — "gap" means difference between groups.**
B) "consensus" means agreement — passage is about difference.
C) "origin" — blank describes the difference itself, not its source.
D) "format" — irrelevant.
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Q53. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Display = "an argument" she "prosecuted with conviction." To prosecute an argument = pursue vigorously.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "Charged with a crime" — no legal context; metaphorical.
B) ■ CORRECT — "Pursued" means carried forward with determination.
C) "Investigated" — different legal action.
D) "Condemned" — she's advancing, not condemning.

TRAP ALERT ■ Legal meaning is the primary trap.

Q54. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Simulations "closely [blank]" real data. "Alignment" + "strengthens confidence" = matching.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "contradict" — opposite of alignment.
B) "supplant" means replace — simulations don't replace data.
C) "precede" — about timing, not agreement.
D) ■ CORRECT — "corroborate" means confirm or support with evidence.

FAST METHOD ■ Simulations match observations = corroborate.

Q55. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Castles "project political authority" and "communicate wealth." Blank = "display."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "conceal" — opposite.
 - B) "diminish" — opposite.
 - C) ■ CORRECT — "advertise" means publicly display.**
 - D) "question" — features don't question power.
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Q56. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Genetic uniformity = fewer barriers to disease. Blank = "susceptible."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "resistant" — opposite; diversity provides resistance, uniformity removes it.
- B) "accustomed" — crops don't get "used to" outbreaks.
- C) ■ CORRECT — "vulnerable" means susceptible to harm.**
- D) "indifferent" — crops don't have emotions.

TRAP ALERT ■ "resistant" is the reversal.

Q57. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Halvorsen says the smooth-universe interpretation is wrong — better instruments would disprove it. Blank = "impossible to maintain."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) ■ CORRECT — "untenable" means impossible to defend or maintain.**
- B) "unprecedented" means never done before — doesn't describe a disproven position.
- C) "indispensable" means essential — opposite.
- D) "unambiguous" means clear — she's saying it's wrong, not unclear.

TRAP ALERT ■ "unambiguous" confuses clarity with correctness.

Q58. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Industry doesn't "simply reflect" sentiment but actively creates it — producing demand for "pasts that never existed."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "documents" means records — it creates sentiment, not records it.
- B) "regulates" means controls through rules — not the right kind of action.
- C) "inherits" — doesn't inherit sentiment.
- D) ■ CORRECT — "manufactures" means creates artificially.**

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Not simply reflect but actively [blank]" = creates, not mirrors.

Q59. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: "Studied neutrality" = deliberately cultivated, rehearsed neutrality. Carefully controlled expression.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "Scholarly" — expression isn't academic.

B) ■ CORRECT — "Practiced" means deliberately cultivated and rehearsed.

C) "Researched" — doesn't fit facial expressions.

D) "Examined" — doesn't describe maintaining an expression.

TRAP ALERT ■ "Scholarly" is the trap based on common meaning of "studied."

Q60. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Traditional narrative: agriculture was required for complex societies. Göbekli Tepe shows complex structures before farming.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "preceded" — the view isn't just about sequence but about necessity.

B) "discouraged" — traditional view doesn't say agriculture hindered complexity.

C) ■ CORRECT — "necessitated" means was necessary for.

D) "documented" — agriculture didn't record societies.

TRAP ALERT ■ "preceded" is the strongest distractor — challenge is about causation (necessary), not sequence (came first).

Q61. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Conflating "how things are" with "how they should be" makes inequalities seem justified.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "illegitimate" — opposite; the philosopher explains how meritocracy makes inequalities seem legitimate.

B) ■ CORRECT — "warranted" means justified or deserved.

C) "negligible" — about size, not justice.

D) "temporary" — about duration, not justification.

Q62. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Parrotfish prevent algae from smothering coral — they're critical.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "incidental" means unimportant — contradicts critical role.

B) "detrimental" means harmful — parrotfish help reefs.

C) ■ CORRECT — "indispensable" means essential and irreplaceable.

D) "peripheral" means marginal — passage presents them as central.

Q63. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Grisha "assessed the situation" and "determined efforts better invested elsewhere." Triage = systematic prioritization.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "Emergency medical treatment" — literal meaning; metaphorical use here.

B) ■ CORRECT — "Ranked prioritization" captures the metaphorical meaning.

C) "Emotional release" — leaving was explicitly "not surrender."

D) "Agricultural planning" — too literal; passage uses medical metaphor.

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Triage" figuratively = deciding where to allocate limited resources by priority.

Q64. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Individual fees add up substantially. Consumers treat each as isolated, not part of growing total.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "transparent" — issue isn't visibility but accumulation.
- B) "voluntary" — true but not the key issue.
- C) "sporadic" — subscriptions are regular, not sporadic.
- D) ■ CORRECT — "cumulative" means increasing by successive additions.**

TRAP ALERT ■ "voluntary" is true but misses the point about accumulation.

Q65. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Frameworks designed for a different era. "Troubling" question → frameworks can't handle it.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "sufficient" — opposite.
 - B) "determined" — doesn't describe fitness for purpose.
 - C) ■ CORRECT — "inadequate" means not sufficient.**
 - D) "enthusiastic" — frameworks don't have emotions.
-

Q66. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Confirmation bias = seeking supportive evidence. Blank = "confirms" or "proves right."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "refutes" — describes evidence people avoid, not seek.
 - B) "destabilizes" — also what people avoid.
 - C) ■ CORRECT — "vindicates" means proves right or justifies.**
 - D) "neutralizes" — would cancel out beliefs, not support them.
-

Q67. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: "Ferocious deliberation" = extremely thorough thought. Not literally violent.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "Violent" — deliberation (careful thought) cannot be physically violent.
- B) "Fearful" — irrelevant.
- C) ■ CORRECT — "Intense" means extreme in degree.**
- D) "Angry" — deliberation isn't angry; it's concentrated.

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Ferocious" + abstract noun = extreme intensity.

Q68. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Institutions "require constant maintenance" and can "erode" — fragile without active care.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "permanent" — contradicts need for maintenance.
- B) "spontaneous" — contradicts "require constant maintenance."

C) "redundant" means unnecessary — passage values institutions.

D) ■ CORRECT — "precarious" means insecure, at risk of failing.

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Require maintenance" + "can erode" = precarious.

Q69. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Bacteria survive extreme heat. Their structure does something to heat's "destabilizing effects" that allows survival.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) ■ CORRECT — "counteracts" means opposes or neutralizes.

B) "amplifies" — bacteria would die if it increased destabilization.

C) "mimics" — bacteria don't imitate heat; they resist it.

D) "conceals" — can't hide from physics.

Q70. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Tomás avoided deciding; now "ground narrowed to a single point" with "no room for evasion." Options shrank to one.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "Become physically thin" — misses the metaphor of shrinking options.

B) ■ CORRECT — "Contract to eliminate alternatives" captures options reducing to one.

C) "Measure precisely" — unrelated.

D) "Stretch outward" — opposite of narrowing.

KEY INSIGHT ■ Circling → ground narrows → no evasion = options disappearing.

Q71. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Museums "appear innovative without fundamentally disrupting." Acquisitions are surface-level.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "transformative" — Tan argues the opposite.

B) ■ CORRECT — "cosmetic" means superficial.

C) "profitable" — about sincerity, not revenue.

D) "spontaneous" — irrelevant.

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Appear innovative without fundamentally disrupting" = cosmetic change.

Q72. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Against isolation, for connection. Shared art, language, trade standards show exchange.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "rivalries" — evidence (shared motifs) suggests cooperation, not competition.

B) "redundancies" — doesn't describe connections between kingdoms.

C) "asymmetries" — passage emphasizes shared/mutual elements, not unequal ones.

D) ■ CORRECT — "interdependencies" means mutual reliance and connection.

Q73. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Findings support language influencing cognition but "stop short" of total determination. Partial support = middle-ground.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "discredited" means disproven — findings support the hypothesis.
- B) ■ CORRECT — "moderate" means middle-ground version.**
- C) "radical" means extreme — passage rejects the "stronger claim."
- D) "obsolete" — findings provide new support.

TRAP ALERT ■ "radical" describes the version rejected ("determines thought entirely").

Q74. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: "How the ground had shifted beneath them" = situation/advantage changed unexpectedly.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "Rotated" — too literal for the metaphor.
 - B) ■ CORRECT — "Changed" captures the figurative meaning.**
 - C) "Relocated" — ground doesn't relocate in this metaphor.
 - D) "Trembled" — passage describes completed change, not ongoing instability.
-

Q75. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Vocabulary evolved but persuasive structures "remained remarkably [blank] across periods." = unchanged.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "contentious" — about stability, not controversy.
 - B) "ephemeral" means short-lived — opposite.
 - C) ■ CORRECT — "stable" means unchanging over time.**
 - D) "opaque" — about persistence, not clarity.
-

Q76. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Removing antibiotics → resistant bacteria outcompeted → resistance decreases. "Counterintuitive."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "intensifies" — the intuitive but wrong answer.
- B) "stabilizes" — change is decrease, not maintenance.
- C) ■ CORRECT — "waned" means declines gradually.**
- D) "diversifies" — about decrease, not variety.

TRAP ALERT ■ "intensifies" is intuitive, but "counterintuitive" signals the opposite.

Q77. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Sister's "silence" was "more eloquent than anything she had said." Silence communicated powerfully.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

- A) "Well-spoken" refers to verbal fluency — silence is not verbal.

B) "Persuasive" — silence communicates emotion, not an argument.

C) "Articulate" means clear in words — silence is not verbal.

D) ■ CORRECT — "Expressive" means conveying meaning powerfully.

TRAP ALERT ■ "Articulate" and "well-spoken" both relate to verbal communication, which the sister is NOT doing.

Q78. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: "Popular characterization" says Byzantium merely preserved Rome. Sokolova says it innovated. Blank = "gets wrong."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "elucidates" means clarifies — characterization ignores innovations.

B) "perpetuates" — could describe continuing a myth, but the object is "innovations," which aren't perpetuated.

C) ■ CORRECT — "misrepresents" means gives a false picture.

D) "corroborates" means confirms — characterization denies innovation.

Q79. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Caterpillar is forced ("manipulate," "unwilling") to guard wasp pupae. Blank = "forcibly drafting."

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "recruiting" implies voluntary enlistment — caterpillar is unwilling.

B) "liberating" means freeing — opposite of forced service.

C) ■ CORRECT — "conscripting" means forcibly drafting into service.

D) "rewarding" — caterpillar receives no benefit.

TRAP ALERT ■ "recruiting" implies willingness; "conscripting" implies force. The caterpillar is unwilling.

Q80. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Replication crisis "paradoxically [blank]" psychology by prompting better methods. "Paradoxically" = opposite of expected.

WHY EACH OPTION IS WRONG:

A) "discredited" — expected outcome, not paradoxical.

B) "fragmented" — not supported by evidence of improvement.

C) "stagnated" — contradicts "catalyst for systemic improvement."

D) ■ CORRECT — "strengthened" = paradoxical result of a crisis.

TRAP ALERT ■ "discredited" is the trap for students who miss "paradoxically."

KEY INSIGHT ■ "Paradoxically" = answer must be opposite of expected. Crisis → strengthened.

TOPIC SUMMARY — VOCABULARY IN CONTEXT

Top 3 Mistakes Students Make

1. ****Falling for Reversal Traps:**** The most common error is selecting a word that means the opposite of what context requires. Students read too quickly and miss contrast markers like "although," "however," "paradoxically," and "despite." About 30–40% of wrong answers in this set are reversal traps (e.g., Q1 "validated" vs. "undermined"; Q57 "indispensable" vs. "untenable"; Q76 "intensifies" vs. "waness").

2. **Choosing the Most Common Meaning of a Word:** In "as used in the text" questions, students default to the primary dictionary definition instead of reading context clues. For example, choosing "detained by police" for "arrested" (Q28), "financial system" for "economy" (Q31), or "scholarly" for "studied" (Q59). The DSAT specifically tests secondary and figurative meanings.
3. **Ignoring the Passage's Logical Structure:** Students focus on the blank in isolation rather than reading the full passage for cause-effect, contrast, or exemplification relationships. The sentence containing the blank almost always has a clue phrase ("even minor disturbances" in Q13, "counterintuitive" in Q76, "paradoxically" in Q80) that dictates the answer.

Top 3 Rules for Vocabulary in Context

1. **Read the Full Passage, Not Just the Sentence:** Context clues are often in the sentence before or after the blank. Look for contrast words (although, however, despite, yet, rather than), cause-effect markers (because, since, as a result), and exemplification (for example, such as, including). These structures tell you whether the blank aligns with or opposes the surrounding information.
2. **Substitute and Check:** Plug each answer choice into the blank and read the full sentence. The correct answer must be both logically consistent AND precise. Many distractors are in the right ballpark but miss a crucial nuance — for instance, "recruiting" implies willingness while "conscripting" implies force (Q79).
3. **For Literary Passages, Track the Extended Metaphor:** When a passage uses figurative language, the word in question almost always has a figurative rather than literal meaning. Look for the vehicle of the metaphor (armor → protection → "wore" means displayed; well → narrowing ground → options disappearing). The literal meaning is almost always the trap answer.

Expected Frequency Per Module

- Module 1 (standard difficulty): 4–6 Vocabulary in Context questions per module (about 15–20% of the 27 R&W questions). Most will be Easy to Medium difficulty.
- Module 2 (adaptive — easier path): 4–6 questions, skewing Easy.
- Module 2 (adaptive — harder path): 4–6 questions, skewing Medium to Hard, with more nuanced vocabulary (untenable, conscripting, precarious) and more complex passage structures.
- Total per test: Approximately 8–12 Vocabulary in Context questions across both modules.

High-Value Vocabulary Words (from this set and DSAT analysis)

Hard-level words to know: untenable, corroborate, conscript, precarious, ephemeral, vindicate, wane, cosmetic (figurative), cumulative, interdependencies, expansive, indispensable, counteract, mitigate, bolster

Medium-level words to know: disparity, dearth, curtail, perfunctory, methodical, opportunistic, discern, undermine, lure, revered, facilitate, contradict, sustained

Easy-level words to know: impact, support, reduce, address, represent, alternate, affordable, sophisticated, fragile, patronize (formal sense)